economists, including Professor K. Jayashankar and G.R. Reddy, and chose the path carefully.

**Q. What were your foremost priorities?**
The first thing we took up was Mission Kakatiya to restore all minor and major irrigation tanks in Telangana—the name came from a dynasty of kings that in the past had laid a massive network of some 75,000 interconnected tanks for irrigation and drinking. Before the split from Andhra Pradesh, these tanks had been criminally neglected and had almost disappeared. Only around 45,000 were left. We restored them when we came to power.

**Q. What impact did it have?**
It made water available for farmers and prevented migration. Paddy cultivation was only around 7 million tonnes when we came to power in 2014. Today, it is over 26 million tonnes, and we are the rice bowl of the South, not far from Punjab's production. By next year, we expect to overtake them.

**Q. Punjab fell into a wheat trap. Telangana seems to be headed for a rice trap. Are you doing something to diversify agriculture production?**
Yes, 100 per cent. We had to first settle down as we were in the doldrums when the state was formed. People have now heaved a sigh of relief. Luckily, in the past decade, there has been no curfew, no strikes, no major law-and-order problems.

**Q. What is your approach towards ensuring law and order in the state?**
My government's policy is for every section, including the minorities, to be happy. They should get the benefits of all the welfare schemes equally. To think of Hindus, Muslims and Christians as separate is senseless. They are all part of our polity. Why should Muslims suffer for being Muslims? We should do something for them. That should be the approach.

**Q. The Uttar Pradesh chief minister used bulldozers and police encounters to ensure law and order. Do you approve of such an approach?**
It is not desirable in a democracy to shoot people at sight. It is not our job to use bulldozers and demolish houses. I oppose that approach very strongly. There is a law-and-order department, there is the judiciary, and it is their job. Look at our approach in Telangana—we make people busy in work. *Phir kaun ladega* (who will fight then)?

**Q. You have placed tremendous emphasis on welfare schemes for farmers, which seems to have become a model for governments in other states.**
I had several brainstorming sessions with agriculture economist Ashok Gulati. He told me that, across the world, agriculture survives only with government support. India is the only country that not only does not support farmers but instead takes from them. So, he advised me to give them cash support. That is why we started the Rythu Bandhu scheme and gave farmers Rs 5,000 per acre as investment subsidy support for every crop, which meant Rs 10,000 a year. Not only farmers, we also focused on welfare for other sections, especially the destitute of all kinds, whether widows, the elderly or others, and gave them pensions of Rs 2,000 a month.

**Q. There is an allegation that one of your major schemes–2BHK Housing–fell far short of its target, and that there was corruption in allotment, especially by your MLAs.**
As a policy, in our welfare schemes, we do not allow MLAS to decide on allotments. We take out a public lottery and people themselves pick the winners. We promised three lakh units and built and delivered them. People are happy.

> **"WHAT CAN I DO IF THE PM SAYS WHATEVER COMES TO HIS MIND AND MAKES UP STORIES (REGARDING KCR APPROACHING HIM TO JOIN NDA)? THE FACT IS, I AM CM, HE IS PM. I NEED TO MAINTAIN BASIC STATE-CENTRE RELATIONS"**

**Q. What explains your dual strategy for power supply–of building capacity and buying from other states?**
Initially, we bought power from Chhattisgarh and other places where it was available. We also planned our own generation and decided it would be done totally by the Telangana government. Private players attacked the policy as did the government of India, but I refuted their criticism. We raised installed power capacity from 6,500 MW to 18,453 MW. Now, we assure 24x7 power supply to all sectors. Earlier, people would buy inverters, converters, stabilisers and generators. Now, all these businesses have had to shut shop.